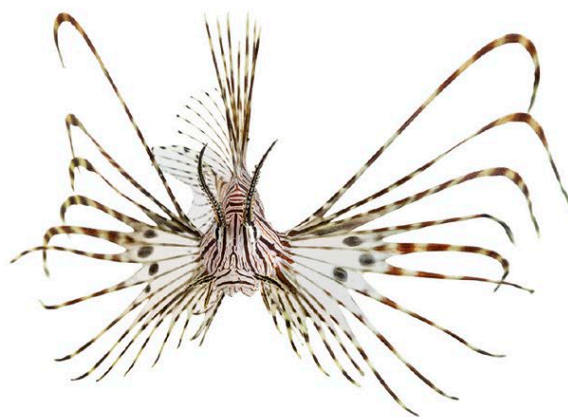


RED LIONFISH

Pterois volitans

The red lionfish is a night hunter, patrolling tropical coral and rocky reefs in the western Pacific in search of small fish and crustaceans. It corrals its prey against the reef by spreading out its wide pectoral fins – one on each side of its body – before gulping in the prey with lightning speed. Sometimes it stalks its prey out in the open, relying on stealth and a final quick rush, similar to a lion hunting on an African plain. Protected by venomous spines, it will often face a diver or potential predator head-on if approached. One male may collect a small harem of females and will charge other males that stray too close. When ready to spawn, the male displays to the female, circling round her before they swim up towards the surface to shed eggs and sperm into the water. After a few days the eggs hatch into planktonic larvae that drift in the plankton for about a month before settling on the seabed.



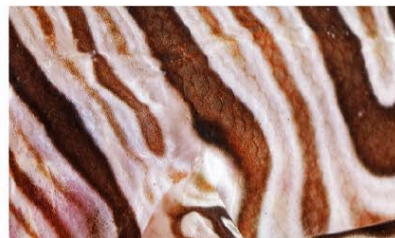
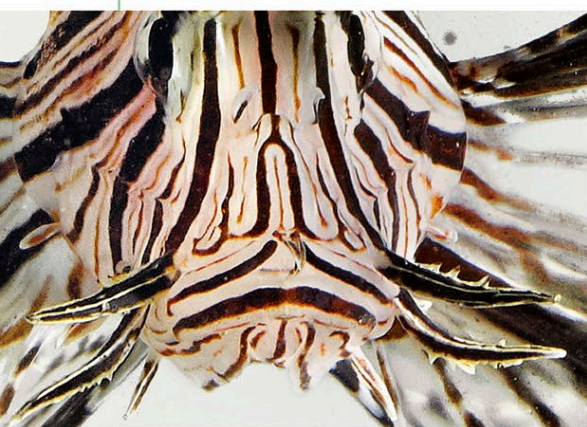
SIZE 45 cm (18 in) in length
HABITAT Coral and rock reefs
DISTRIBUTION Pacific Ocean, introduced into W. Atlantic
DIET Fish and crustaceans

> VIBRANT WARNING

The contrasting striped pattern of the red lionfish acts as a warning to predators that the fish is venomous and they should keep away. On land, stinging wasps use a similar method to avoid being eaten.

< MENACING PREDATOR

This efficient predator has been released from aquariums into the Caribbean, where it is a threat to native reef fish. It hunts at dusk using its large eyes and acute sense of smell.

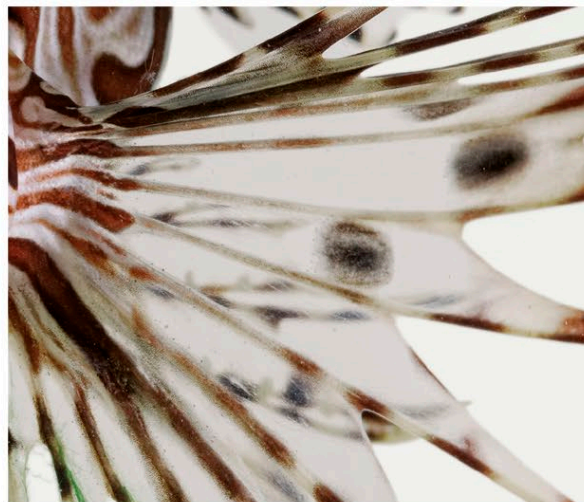


head
tentacle

eye is disguised
by a dark stripe
that confuses
potential predators

^ VARIED STRIPES

The striped pattern differs between individuals, and becomes much less obvious in breeding males, which can be very dark.



< PECTORAL FINS

The soft rays of the pectoral fins are joined together for part of their length by a fine membrane, which is marked with circular splotches of colour.

VENOMOUS SPINES >

Sharp spines in this fish's dorsal, anal, and pelvic fins can be used to inject venom that causes extreme pain in humans, but is rarely fatal. The spines are purely defensive.



fleshy "whiskers"
may help disguise
the fish's large,
open mouth when
approaching prey

< TAIL UP

Lionfish often hang slightly head down and tail up, ready to pounce on passing prey. The tail helps the fish to maintain this position, rather than to swim fast.